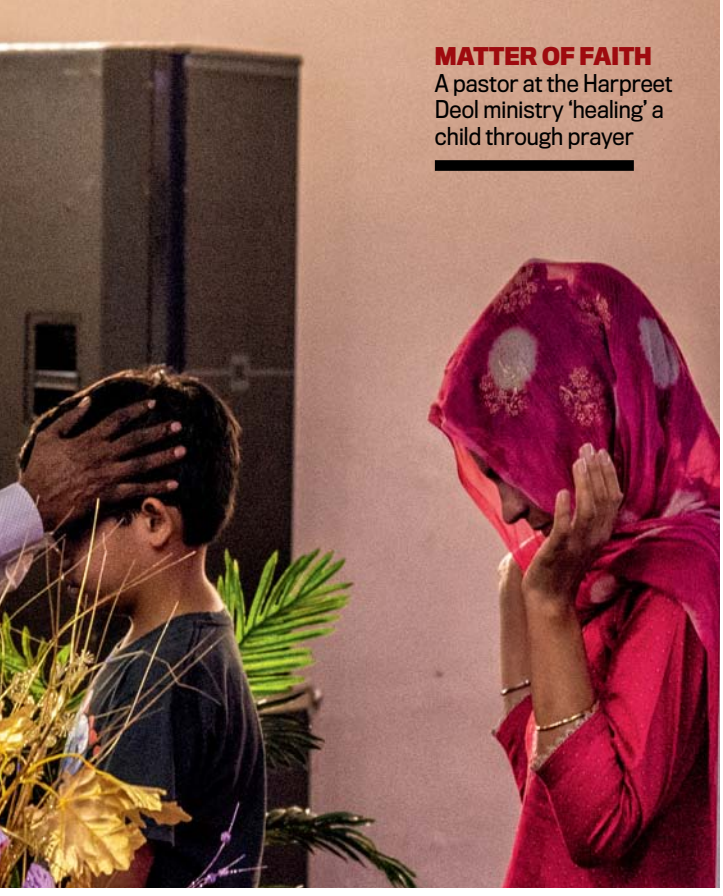


MATTER OF FAITH
A pastor at the Harpreet Deol ministry 'healing' a child through prayer

Punjab, facing multiple traumas–the militancy years, farm distress, a drug-addled generation–proved fertile soil for what they call the "Christianity for the underclasses of the world"

mis, and their distant offshoots like Dera Sacha Sauda. Indeed, the whole Dera movement—offering a spiritual potpourri of Hindu, Sikh and Sufi Islam—is a heterodox tradition, which appeals primarily to Dalits alienated by elite caste domination of the mainstream religions. The Deras, too, used colourful congregations and musical nights to attract followers, but a series of scandals and controversies eclipsed their charm somewhat. "That space has been grabbed by the quickfix Christian healers," says Jaibans Singh, a Patiala-based commentator.

But before that, the Dera movement armed Dalits with the confidence to organise a movement for land rights and generally stand against the oppression of Jat Sikhs in rural Punjab. Jats, less than 20 per cent, lord it over the state's politics—only two post-Independence CMs, Giani Zail Singh and Charanjit Singh Channi, have been non-Jat. They also own 93 per cent of agrarian land and thus control the rural economy. You will also find them in the top echelons of police, bureaucracy and the judiciary. Their writ is absolute in the Sikh institutions. But a rebellious spirit has taken root—even on religious matters. As late as 2010, Dera Sach Khand proclaimed, controversially, that Ravidassias were a separate religion and that their places of worship must replace the Guru Granth Sahib with Sant Ravidas's Amritbani.

A mutual distancing on caste lines has anyway been tangible for years within Sikhism, with the mushrooming of separate gurdwaras for Mazhabis, Ramdassis, Jats and backwards like Ramgarhia Sikhs. Separate community marriage halls and crematoriums are not rare either. "These are the faultlines into which the Charismatic pastors have moved in, almost as an extension of the Deras. But who left this space open?" asks Kali. Historian Rajkumar Hans sees a deeper basis to the phenomenon, reading it as a sign of the culture's innate heterodoxy. "Geographically as well as psychologically, Punjab has a certain openness. Never forget, it is the home of Taxila. The Buddhist imprint runs very deep in its consciousness. That's why Brahminical Hinduism was never especially strong here. It was the egalitarian, casteless movements like the Siddhas and Nath panthis that held sway. Nanak came out of precisely that ethos. The Sufis also blended into that," says Prof. Hans, who sees the Jat domination of Sikhism as a latter-day aberration.

Back at Khambra, the Akshardham of Charismatic Christianity, those questions recede into a blur of ecstasy. Some 5,000 congregants are swaying to a hymnal chorus that, with its simple descending lines, could be a Bollywood ballad. They tick all economic boxes—some of them could be like middle-class Punjabi families on a Sunday dosa outing, till you see the mood up close. A young couple is seated with three portraits of close kin laid out in front. There is a pregnant lady, seriously immersed. The ones standing hold small plastic vials with pink-coloured holy water to their foreheads as they sway, holding out the other hand, eyes closed, as if an epiphany was coming on. Even the attendants are caught up in the mood, which peaks occasionally as a contralto voice shoots up above the chorus, and all around the stadium-sized hall, under a massive steel-and-alloy frame ceiling reminiscent of an airport hall. Here, in front of four massive video screens, with a giant cross turning around like a logo on the main screen, it's a different kind of transport: the Great Indian Hope Trick. In the evening, the 'Instant healing testimony Sunday deliverance' meeting is a professionally managed stage show, with strategically placed cameras, and music moving skilfully to a crescendo as a roll-call of devotees come on stage to relate how they have been cured miraculously by Narula's magic hand. "*Andhe dekhte hain, bahre sunte hain, langde chalte hain, meri paralysis bhi theek ho jaayegi*...." says a girl from Maharashtra. On the paddy fields just outside, itinerant Gujjar tribesmen—beyond the pale of everything in Punjab—are carting away loads of *parali* (stubble) for their buffaloes. Whatever they can, that is. The rest burns, and joins the smoke that hangs over Punjab. ■